CASE STUDY

POULOMI DAS | 29 | *Model-actress*

"Women's empowerment on TV is garbage"

Two months ago, Poulomi Das was on the verge of bagging a lead role in a TV show only to learn that the channel rejected her on grounds of her skin colour. "I got to know from friends at the channel that they didn't take me because 'she is too dark, she should look like an MD' (Managing Director)," Poulomi recounts. "These channels which show women empowerment, they are bullsh***ing. If you look into their minds, it's full of garbage and outdated ideas. In India, none of us is white. It's 200 years of British colonisation and the prejudiced mindset which still persists."

Naysayers and bullies don't deter Poulomi who proudly goes as 'The Brown Queen' on Instagram. She has learned to give it back to colourists, be it on Bigg Boss OTT (2024), where a fellow contestant made a derogatory remark on her complexion, or online trolls. "They can't tamp down my aura because they think I am not good enough. When they said you don't look like a lead, I was like 'In my life story, I am the lead'," she says, having appeared in shows like *Suhani Si Ek Ladki* and *Kartik Purnima*.

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In 2020-21, Poulomi would become the face of Hindustan Lever's Glow & Lovely, a feat she's proud of since it involved the brand changing its strategy from being a fairness to a BB cream. "If they are owning their mistake and changing their motive and doing justice to my skin tone, then why shouldn't I support them? We all need to evolve," she says. Enjoying a vacation in Kerala, she says she was going to come back 10 times darker than she is. "I'm loving it."

–Suhani Singh

being equal, a light-skinned person could end up being favoured for work opportunities."

INDIANS AND COLOURISM

Colourism, a term coined by the celebrated Black writer Alice Walker in 1982 to describe the prejudicial or preferential treatment meted out to people of the same race on the basis of colour, is an open secret in our country. Some scholars like Dr Vivek Kumar, a sociologist at the School of Social Sciences in Jawaharlal Nehru University in Delhi, trace its origin to when the first fair-skinned Indo-Aryans encountered the dark-skinned Dravidians, original inhabitants of the land, and then began to rule over the people and designated themselves as nobility. "Racial theory was constructed in sociological terms with the advent of the Aryans," says Kumar. He, however, stops short of attributing colour discrimination to the caste system, saying it was in its infancy when skin colour began to be assigned value. It was organised more around the professions individuals practised than by birth, and became hereditary only much later, he hypothesises.



"Women's bodies are their currency in the marriage market. For a dark-skinned man who is doing well financially, marrying a light-skinned woman is a trophy"

RADHIKA PARAMESWARAN, *Professor, The Media School, Indiana University, US*

Kumar instead attributes the modern-day obsession with skin colour to the colonialists—the Portuguese, the French, the Dutch and, eventually, the British, who stayed the longest. "Our gods—Vishnu, Shiva, Ram, Krishna—are all portrayed as dark-skinned. Draupadi—the beautiful queen of the Mahabharata—is explicitly dark-skinned," he says. "The association of beauty and aspiration with white skin is a gift of European colonial rulers." British ethnographer Herbert Hope Risley, in fact, classified Indians into broad racial types in 1915, identifying Dravidians as dark-complexioned and the Indo-Aryans as fairer. This classification hewed close to India's own colour associations with caste, wherein Brahmins were regarded to be generally fair-skinned and lower castes and tribals believed